Where Mom Keeps Everything

A one-page organizer for her statements, policies, deeds and tax returns: where each one is, how recent it is, and who has it.

The bank statements come in the mail and go in the kitchen drawer. The insurance policy is in a box in the closet, probably. The deed is “somewhere safe,” and the tax returns may be with whoever prepares them.

This page doesn't ask you to read or understand any of it. Go through it with Mom, and for each thing write where it is, how recent it is, and who has it.

WHAT TO COLLECT	WHERE IT IS	ITS DATE	WHO HAS IT
Recent statements for checking and savings accounts, and any CDs			
Recent statements for investment, brokerage and retirement accounts			
Social Security and pension paperwork			
Life insurance policies and annuity contracts			
Long-term care insurance policy, if she has one			
Health insurance cards and plan papers			
Deed to her home, and records for any other real estate			
Vehicle titles, and papers for any business interest or other significant property			
Recent tax returns			
Statements for any mortgage, loan or credit card			

What hasn't turned up yet, and who will look for it

Anything above with an empty line. Put a name next to each.

FOR EXAMPLE No copy of the life insurance policy. Mom will ask her agent for one the next time she calls.

Where the file will be kept, and who Mom wants to know

One secure place, chosen by Mom, and the name of anyone she'd like to know where it is.

FOR EXAMPLE Gray file box, bottom of the hall closet. Mom wants Denise to know. We'll look through it again in the spring.

How to use it

- Write the date printed on each item. If it has no date, write “undated.”
- Leave account numbers, Social Security numbers and passwords off this page. Just say where the paper is.
- Don't rewrite or summarize a document here, and don't move one without Mom knowing where it went.
- Put today's date on the page, and agree with Mom when you'll look at it again.

What this page doesn't do

It doesn't explain what any statement, policy or deed means, and it doesn't say which of them matter for Medicaid planning. If you read something you don't understand, that's a question for the company that issued it or for a professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where each of Mom's financial documents is kept, and which ones haven't turned up yet. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care. Keep this page beside you while you answer.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Several rows follow the list on the Family Caregiver Alliance's form for recording where important papers are kept. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's working list for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Where to Find My Important Papers